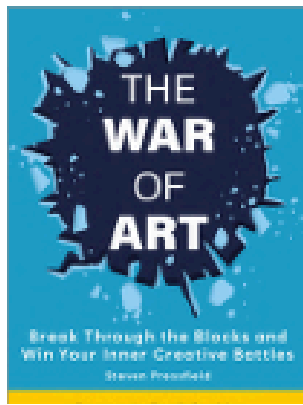




THE WAR OF ART

Break Through the Blocks and
Win Your Inner Creative Battles

Steven Pressfield



The Big “So What”

In this book, Steven Pressfield explores how to overcome creative blocks to unlock your full potential, and achieve what you were born to do. The ideas are valuable for artists, entrepreneurs, athletes, and anyone trying to break through their internal barriers to success.



Introduction



In the context of this book, being “creative” refers using your intrinsic talents, insights, or passions to create or produce something new.

- This goes beyond the traditional definition of “artistic endeavors” like painting, writing, or music. It includes any endeavor where innovation and self-expression are key, such as entrepreneurship, scientific research, and product development. It’s about bringing forth something that’s deeply unique and authentic.
- To do that, you must overcome strong internal resistance including fear and self-doubt.



This book describes the invisible enemy to creativity, which Pressfield names “Resistance”, and how to win the battle against it.

- This summary addresses the struggle against Resistance in 3 parts:
 - (i) What is Resistance?

KEY QUOTES

“When inspiration touches talent, she gives birth to truth and beauty.”
—Robert McKee

“The most important thing about art is to work. Nothing else matters except sitting down every day and trying.”

- (ii) Winning the war against Resistance
- (iii) Living your creative potential



Part 1: What is Resistance?



Pressfield depicts Resistance as the arch-nemesis of creativity. It is an omnipresent force actively working against you, preventing you from doing what you're meant to do. To successfully fight Resistance, you must first recognize and understand it.



Recognizing and Understanding Resistance



Resistance is an internal, unseen enemy. You can't see, hear, touch, or smell Resistance. However, you can feel it, like an energy field repelling you from your work, or pushing back against your creative efforts.

- Resistance exists to thwart creativity. It affects everyone, and it's not personal.



It's powered by fear—if you can conquer your fear, you can conquer Resistance.

- The more important the task at hand, the greater the Resistance. So, you can use the level of Resistance as a compass to point toward what you should do.



Resistance manifests in various forms, including procrastination, self-doubt, and self-destructive behaviors.

- We procrastinate by putting off a task till later. The more you procrastinate, the more it becomes a habit.
- We might also seek out instant gratification through sex, drugs, sweet/fatty foods, or mindless entertainment.
- Resistance could also appear as a voice in your head, telling you all the reasons you can't/shouldn't do what you want to do.
- Resistance can even lead to self-dramatization and victimization. Doctors estimate that 70-80% of patients aren't

KEY QUOTES

"Every sun casts a shadow, and genius's shadow is Resistance."

"Rule of thumb: The more important a call or action is to our soul's evolution, the more Resistance we will feel toward pursuing it."

"It's not the writing part that's hard. What's hard is sitting down to write. What keeps us from sitting down is Resistance."

"Casting yourself as a victim is the antithesis of doing your work. Don't do it."

truly sick; they're just dramatizing their condition to get attention or to get out of a situation.



Resistance can also sabotage us through the actions and needs of others close to us. It manifests as external distractions, when it actually comes from deep inside us.

- When you decide to tackle an important task, or are at the verge of a breakthrough, Resistance ensures that something urgent suddenly pops up. This could be anything from family emergencies to an unexpected illness, keeping you from your desired path.
- Resistance makes you criticize others. You project your fears and inaction onto others instead of tackling your own challenges.



Resistance doesn't just act through our action/inaction. It also acts through feelings of restlessness, unhappiness, and self-doubt, pushing us to abandon our true callings.

- The more fear and resistance you feel toward something, the more important it is likely to be. Otherwise you will simply feel indifferent toward it.



Resistance is also associated with fundamentalism. Both artists and fundamentalists deal with existential questions like "Who am I?" and "Why am I here?" However, they respond differently.

- Artists emerged from more modern, affluent and stable societies. They embrace freedom, and use their creativity to explore and express their individual identities. They believe in progress and seek to contribute to a better world through artistic expression.
- Fundamentalists arise from societies facing defeat or despair. They reject modernization and attempt to restore order based on rigid, traditional values. This is a form of Resistance that blocks the freedom of progress and personal expression.



Part 2: Winning the War Against Resistance



The best way to fight Resistance is to become a professional.

KEY QUOTES

"Individuals who are realized in their own lives almost never criticize others."

"The more scared we are of a work or calling, the more sure we can be that we have to do it."

"The opposite of love isn't hate; it's indifference."

- In the context of this book, being “professional” is about embracing a mindset, not a role like a lawyer or a doctor.
- Professionals treat their work with the seriousness and dedication it deserves. They show up consistently to do their work, continually hone their skills and self-mastery, and remain committed to their craft over the long haul.



Professionals vs Amateurs

There are several differences between a pro and an amateur.



Dedication: Amateurs treat their craft like a hobby, engaging in their pursuits part-time or when it's convenient. Pros are fully committed to their craft—they treat it as a full-time, long-term vocation. They integrate their work into their daily lives, working consistently on their craft 7 days a week.



Love and passion: Amateurs treat their work as something they enjoy or pursue “for fun”. Pros love their craft so much that they dedicate their lives to it, making it their life's work.



Money and motivation: Amateurs see their craft as a sideline, not something they do for “serious money”. Pros get paid for their work, though there are important distinctions to note:

- Pros work for money but not for the love of money. Their main motivation is still their passion for the craft.
- However, monetary compensation offers extra rewards and validation, allowing them to devote their lives to the craft, and further motivating them to excel at it.



Pros have a professional detachment that's crucial for combatting Resistance.

- They don't over-identify with their work or instruments (e.g. their voice or acting skills). For example, Madonna's cone bras and sexy clothes are just tools to shape her public persona; they don't define who she is at the core.
- This allows them to take pride in their work without becoming prideful, and to receive criticism constructively. Amateurs, on the other hand, take criticisms personally and can get paralyzed by the fear of failure or rejection.

KEY QUOTES

“A pro views her work as craft, not art.”

“Technically, the pro plays for pay. But in the end, he does it for love.”

“Playing the game for money produces the proper professional attitude.”

“To the gods the supreme sin is not rape or murder, but pride. To think of yourself as a mercenary, a gun for hire, implants the proper humility. It purges pride and preciousness.”

- Many professionals (such as screenwriters in Hollywood) even incorporate themselves as businesses to:
 - (i) Gain tax and financial benefits; and
 - (ii) Manage their work effectively, successfully wearing 2 hats—as the artist who does the work, and the businessperson who hires the artist.
- Similarly, Pressfield treats his writing like a business, holding weekly status meetings with himself to outline/assign tasks for the week, and keeping separate financial accounts for himself and his business entity.



Pros' workmanlike attitude helps them to maintain a practical, steady approach, so they can sustain the work over the long haul, instead of burning out too quickly.

- Unlike amateurs, who are impatient for quick rewards and results, pros accept that success and mastery take time. They're patient enough to wait for delayed gratification.



Pros embrace hardship and challenges. Pressfield's experience in the Marine Corps taught him the importance of taking pride in one's struggles to cultivate perseverance and resilience.

- Amateurs avoid new ventures or creative work due to the fear of failure, rejection, or solitude. They are afraid to express themselves and risk being ridiculed, and are fearful that success will alienate them from the people/things they're familiar with.
- Pros act in spite of fear, not in the absence of it. In the process, they uncover new levels of support, understanding and fulfilment.
 - (i) Even when they work in solitude, they're never truly alone. They're always accompanied by their "Muse" or creative spirit, surrounded by the characters in their creations, and/or connected with the audience they're creating for.
 - (ii) When they're deeply in flow or immersed in their work, they feel a profound level of support and inspiration.



Amateurs rely on external sources of validation, whereas pros focus on self-mastery and expressing their creative vision.

KEY QUOTES

"You-the-writer may get a swelled head, but you-the-boss remember how to take yourself down a peg."

"If we think of ourselves as a corporation, it gives us a healthy distance on ourselves."

"The professional arms himself with patience, not only to give the stars time to align in his career, but to keep himself from flaming out in each individual work."

"He has to know how to be miserable...Because this is war, baby. And war is hell."

"These characters [are] absolutely fascinating to us. They are us. Meaner, smarter, sexier versions of ourselves."

- Pressfield advises against relying on external sources of support or inspiration for creative challenges. Forget about external workshops or support groups, as these can end up distracting you from your real work. Instead, devote time for solitary work, looking inward to cultivate self-awareness, self-belief, and to discover and express your inner voice.
- Don't wait for the perfect time or circumstances to start. The more you give in to Resistance, the stronger it becomes.
 - (i) Personal challenges cannot hinder you unless you allow them to. Tolstoy wrote "War and Peace" even though he had 13 kids, and Lance Armstrong won the Tour de France while he had cancer. Recognize your justifications for what they truly are—excuses.
 - (ii) Once you start taking action, you'll find the justifications and excuses fading away. In fact, the process of engaging deeply in creative work can be healing and transformative.
- Amateurs dream/talk of grandeur, while pros focus on doing the work. Instead of waiting for inspiration before they start to work, pros focus on techniques and tangibles to keep moving forward. They know that if they persist, inspiration will come eventually.
- Pros recognize that real victory isn't about the end-results, but the process of conquering themselves.
 - (i) They give themselves fully to their work regardless of the outcomes, maintaining their self-belief and commitment.
 - (ii) They fight their war against Resistance regardless of internal/external challenges, injustice or bad luck.
 - (iii) They realize that the real battle is in their own minds, and seek to continually improve and reinvent themselves.

During the 2001 Masters, Tiger Woods had to halt mid-swing when he was unexpectedly interrupted by a spectator's camera click. Instead of reacting impulsively, he recomposed himself and successfully continued his game—like a real pro.



Despite their successes, pros remain grounded and respectful of their craft.

- They might develop a distinct, authentic style, but they don't flaunt it nor impose it on others. They recognize that their

KEY QUOTES

"The professional cannot allow the actions of others to define his reality. Tomorrow morning the critic will be gone, but the writer will still be there facing the blank page."

"It's one thing to lie to ourselves. It's another thing to believe it."

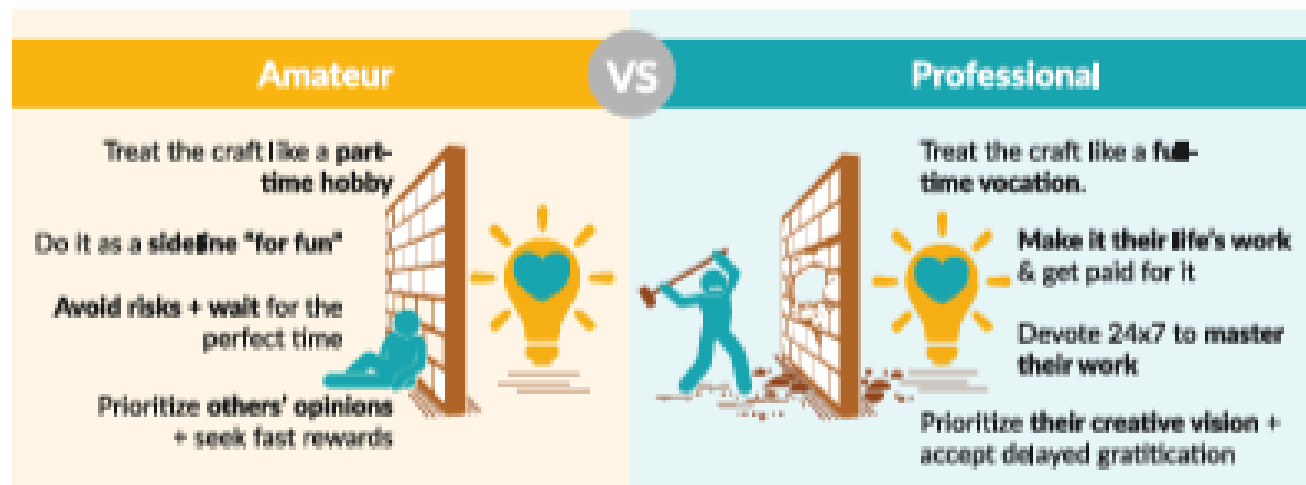
"A professional schools herself to stand apart from her performance, even as she gives herself to it heart and soul."

"The professional keeps his eye on the doughnut and not on the hole."

"The professional respects his craft. He does not consider himself superior to it."

craft is built upon the contributions of many people before them, keeping any snobbery in check.

- They ask for help, humbly acknowledging that they don't know everything. There are always people they can learn from, and people who can complement their skills (e.g. specialists like lawyers or accountants).



Turning Pro



In short, Resistance is persistent, but the pro wins by being even more relentless.



To become a pro, you just have to make a firm decision to make the shift.

- In his late 20s, Pressfield was at a low point. He had failed to finish any of his writing projects, and even his marriage had broken down. Resistance was winning the war. He finally made a real decision to buckle down and finish his book, shutting out all external distractions.
- Even though Pressfield never found a buyer for his first book, the act of finishing the book was in itself major personal victory. It took another 20 years before he made a breakthrough with *The Legend of Bagger Vance*, but he attributed the turning point in his career to that moment when he turned pro.



Most of us are already professionals in our jobs.

- We show up daily, and keep working until the time is up.
- We might change jobs/companies, but we're committed to working and building our careers for the long-term.

KEY QUOTES

"The counterfeit innovator is wildly self-confident. The real one is scared to death."

"There never was a moment, and never will be, when we are without the power to alter our destiny. This second, we can turn the tables on Resistance."

"There's no mystery to turning pro. It's a decision brought about by an act of will. We make up our mind to view ourselves as pros and we do it."

"I can state absolutely that the term of my life can be divided into two parts: before turning pro, and after."

"The professional tackles the project that will make him stretch. He takes on the assignment that will bear him into uncharted waters, compel him to explore unconscious parts of himself."

- We do this because the stakes are high, e.g. we need the income, or we don't want to let down our family/colleagues.
- We get paid for our work, so we treat it seriously and seek to become more effective at it.
- We take pride in our work, but it doesn't define our identity.

It's time to apply the same level of dedication to the creative work we were born to do.



Part 3: Living Your Creative Potential



Collaborating with Higher Forces



Although Resistance is formidable, it can be countered by an opposing force, which Pressfield calls "the Muse".

- Pressfield believes that there are higher forces at work—whether you call it God, spirit, consciousness, or infinite intelligence. These forces are ethereal and timeless, and they work through mortals like us to translate intangible potential into tangible creations.
- In classical mythology, Muses were goddesses that inspired the arts and sciences. Pressfield depicts the Muse as a guiding presence for artists. The Muse whispers seeds of inspiration into human ears, leading to monumental works like Shakespeare's "Hamlet" or Beethoven's "Fifth Symphony".



The creative process involves not just techniques, but a collaboration with higher powers. Pressfield starts each work day with a personal prayer to invoke the Muse, asking for inspiration to create multi-dimensional stories that can last the test of time.

- The mirrors how ancient leaders and creators sought divine support to guide their endeavors. This ritual opens Pressfield to a flow of creative ideas and energies. It also reminds him to stay humble and connected, to sustain and complete his work.



In other words, you can see an artistic endeavor as both (i) a battle against Resistance and (ii) a communion with higher

KEY QUOTES

"As Resistance works to keep us from becoming who we were born to be, equal and opposite powers are counterpoised against it. These are our allies and angels."

"Things that you think are nothing, as weightless as air, are actually powerful substantial forces, as real and as solid as earth."

"More than make it great, make it live. And not from one angle only, but in all its many bearings."

*"Whatever you can do, or dream you can, begin it. Boldness has genius, magic, and power in it. Begin it now."
— W.H. Murray*

forces. The best way to leverage such intangible forces is to commit to the creative process—get started, and keep doing the work.

- When you truly commit to start on a creative project, something transformative happens. Unseen forces around you are mobilized, bringing helpful coincidences and resources to aid your creative journey.
- During the process of creation, moments of insights might also surface unexpectedly, such as new ideas/solutions or insights on what to correct or improve. This often occurs when your mind is free from the immediate task at hand, such as during a walk. These subconscious cognitive processes are available to everyone, not just “creative” people.



Embracing Your Calling



Ego vs Self. There's a distinction between the Ego (which focuses on material existence and survival) and the Self (which sees the broader, interconnected, and spiritual aspects of life. The creative battle often lies between these two, with the Ego resisting change and the Self seeking to create and evolve.



Resistance is fueled by fear, especially the fear of success.

- We're afraid of facing the unknown, losing our familiar comforts or our loved ones. Pressfield assures us that such fears are unfounded—as you embrace your potential, it will only open up new levels of understanding and fulfilment.



We are not born as empty shells to be shaped by society. Each of us is born with a distinct identity and intrinsic purpose.

- Our goal in life is to discover and realize our inherent potential, be it artistic creation, nurturing a family, or challenging societal injustices.
- Often, people's life priorities change drastically once they're faced with their mortality, e.g. a terminal illness. Don't wait for a crisis to start focusing on what matters. Start cultivating your self-awareness and proactively resolve any internal conflicts—Pressfield believes that this will help to prevent unfulfilled potential from manifesting as mental or physical ailments.

KEY QUOTES

“When we sit down day after day and keep grinding, something mysterious starts to happen. A process is set into motion by which, inevitably and infallibly, heaven comes to our aid.”

“The Ego produces Resistance and attacks the awakening artist.”

“We know that if we embrace our ideals, we must prove worthy of them. And that scares the hell out of us.”

“None of us are born as passive generic blobs waiting for the world to stamp its imprint on us. Instead we show up possessing already a highly refined and individuated soul.”

“Our job in this lifetime is not to shape ourselves into some ideal we imagine we ought to be, but to find out who we already are and become it.”



Artists thrive when they focus on their skills and passions, instead of competing for external recognition or status.

- All human beings derive psychological security either hierarchically or territorially.
 - (i) A *territorial approach* means deriving your motivation and fulfillment from your work/domain, without the influence of rivals or the need for external validation.
 - (ii) A *hierarchical approach* means focusing on social or professional rank, or how you stack up against others.
- Artists thrive within a territorial framework. By staying true to their vision, they can produce work that's genuine and original. It shifts the focus from trying to surpass others, toward mastering their craft and expressing themselves authentically and innovatively. When you're working in your territory:
 - (i) You feel energized and motivated with a deep sense of intrinsic enjoyment;
 - (ii) You'd still do the work even if no one else was around; and
 - (iii) For every ounce of love and effort you put in, the territory gives back in kind so you feel rejuvenated (not drained).
- For example, a painter finds true fulfillment when she's absorbed in the colors and strokes that bring her vision to life, regardless of whether anyone sees or critiques the final product. A writer feels energized when he's writing about a topic he cares deeply about, regardless of whether it becomes a bestseller.
- By contrast, hacks work solely for commercial success or public approval. They prioritize market demand over personal vision, delivering what they think people want to see/hear instead of following their inner compass.



Ultimately, artists are intermediaries between higher realms and the tangible world, channeling unseen energies into their creations.

- They are humble before their craft. They recognize that their work is created through them, not by them.

KEY QUOTES

"In the hierarchy, the artist looks up and looks down. The one place he can't look is that place he must: within."

"The artist cannot look to others to validate his efforts for his calling...The artist must operate territorially. He must do his work for its own sake."

"A territory is a closed feedback loop. Our role is to put in effort and love; the territory absorbs this and gives it back to us in the form of well-being."

"As the mother-to-be bears her child within her, so the artist or innovator contains her new life. No one can help her give it birth. But neither does she need any help."

- Look inward to see/feel what's growing in you, and explore how you can best bring it forth into the world.



To actualize your creative potential, see your craft as a vital contribution to the world, not a means to personal glory.

- Focus on the process of creation, without attachment to the outcomes.
- Treat your artistic endeavor as an offering to a higher power. In so doing, you deepen your spiritual connection and contribute to the collective human progress towards enlightenment.



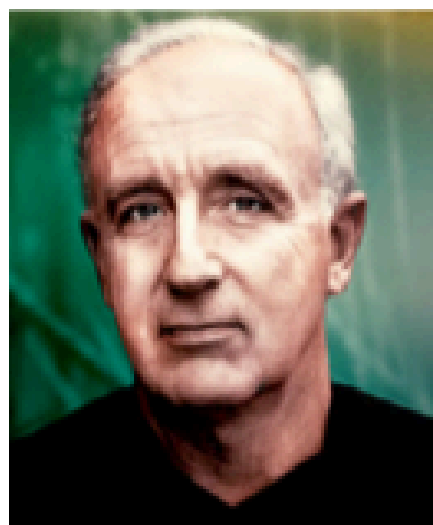
Other Details in the Book to Look out For

To realize your potential and do what you were born to do, it's crucial to overcome Resistance and connect with your higher Calling. The real battle is internal—to master yourself and persist with your creative endeavors, not to gain external recognition or status. In the book, Pressfield shares his personal struggles, experiences and perspectives to motivate readers in their creative pursuits. For more details, please visit <https://stevenpressfield.com>.



About the Author

Steven Pressfield (born 1943) is an American author, known for his historical fiction, nonfiction, and screenplays. He spent 27 years writing—taking on a variety of jobs to support himself—before achieving significant literary success. He has worked as an advertising copywriter, schoolteacher, tractor-trailer driver, bartender, oilfield roustabout, attendant in a mental hospital, and fruit-picker.



His breakout novel, *The Legend of Bagger Vance*, was later adapted into a major motion picture.

KEY QUOTES

"I trusted what I wanted, not what I thought would work. I did what I myself thought was interesting, and left its reception to the gods."

"Creative work is not a selfish act or a bid for attention on the part of the actor. It's a gift to the world and every being in it. Don't cheat us of your contribution. Give us what you've got."